

SAP BTP and Operational Excellence in Swiss Financial Services (Banking & Insurance)

SAP's Business Technology Platform (BTP) is a unified, cloud-based platform that combines data management, analytics, AI/ML and application development to **streamline operations and accelerate innovation** ¹. In banking and insurance finance, SAP BTP can automate and integrate end-to-end processes – from transaction posting to financial close – enabling faster closes, higher data accuracy and lower costs. By providing prebuilt integrations, intelligent services (RPA, AI-based document processing, smart agents) and real-time analytics, SAP BTP helps finance organizations “*streamline operations, improve decision-making and innovate more quickly*” ¹. In Switzerland, where banks and insurers face strict regulatory oversight (FINMA) and high security standards, BTP's cloud services (available in local data centers) offer both the flexibility of modern cloud architecture and the compliance controls required. The following sections analyze how SAP BTP drives cost efficiency, automation and agility in finance for Swiss financial institutions, and how a cloud-based BTP approach compares to on-premise, in light of Swiss regulations. Real-world examples and guidelines are cited throughout.

Accelerating Financial Operations and Closing Processes

SAP BTP dramatically **speeds up and de-risks the financial close**. For example, the SAP Advanced Financial Closing solution on BTP provides pre-configured closing templates, workflow orchestration and real-time monitoring, so that closing tasks are executed in parallel rather than sequentially ² ³. In practice this means the system can automatically trigger and track each step (reconciliations, journal entries, disclosures), alerting teams to delays and enforcing key controls. According to SAP, BTP-enabled closing automation “improves governance and compliance, drives efficiency, and gains transparency” in close management ². The platform “streamlines manual tasks and accelerates your closing” by using notifications, optimized workflows and automated escalations ³. For instance, manual email and spreadsheet hand-offs can be replaced by automated RPA bots or SAP **Build Process Automation** workflows, removing error-prone steps ⁴.

- *Automated, template-driven closing:* SAP's solution provides best-practice closing templates and sequencing, reducing custom design. Shared processes (e.g. for accruals or intercompany eliminations) are defined once and reused across entities. This cuts redundant effort.
- *Elimination of manual bottlenecks:* SAP-curated bots and low-code workflows can “*eliminate reliance on error-prone e-mail and spreadsheet tasks*”, automatically executing routine steps and logging completion ⁴. Document verification, approvals and even simple journal entries can be automated, providing clear audit trails.
- *Real-time transparency:* With SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC) on BTP, management sees live dashboards of close progress. As one SAP case study reports, customers achieved “**>95% faster metrics delivery**” (from 3 days to on-demand) and a **9-day reduction in quarter-end close** by consolidating reporting into one cloud platform ⁵ ⁶.

These capabilities translate into substantial cost savings. Rather than hundreds of man-hours of preparation and reconciliation, finance teams use BTP-driven tools to ingest data and highlight issues. For example, Swiss Re's finance transformation (Project Orion) removed lengthy manual steps: raw financial data from legacy ledgers was “*automatically loaded from legacy systems... (no exhaustive manual*

data reconciliations and validations are needed anymore)" ⁷ . By contrast, the old process involved collecting figures by hand from multiple systems and "writing offline comments... stored in multiple places" ⁷ . After BTP integration (using SAP Analytics Cloud, Data Warehouse Cloud, etc.), Swiss Re eliminated thousands of manual effort-hours each quarter. SAP reports similar gains globally: using BTP-based enterprise performance management, one customer closed **400+ entities every month on a single system**, accelerating metric delivery by >95% and shaving 9 days off the quarter-close ⁵ ⁶ .

Key benefits: Reduced headcount in closing, shorter cycle times, fewer late adjustments and audit findings. By automating the end-to-end close cycle, BTP cuts the effort (and thereby cost) of finance operations.

Automation and Data Quality in Finance

Beyond closing, SAP BTP brings **intelligent automation** to routine finance tasks, reducing manual intervention and data errors throughout the organization. Key capabilities include **RPA / workflow automation, AI-driven document processing**, and **integrated data services**.

- *Robotic and workflow automation:* SAP's Intelligent RPA (via SAP Build Process Automation) can automate data entry and transaction flows (e.g. invoice posting, vendor onboarding). Finance teams can build low-code workflows that route approvals and reminders, eliminating email chains. For example, pre-built bots can match invoices to purchase orders or clear simple exceptions, drastically cutting manual work. SAP notes that automating even a single accrual process can yield a *100% digital audit trail* with "every closing task documented" ⁸ .
- *AI-based finance services:* SAP BTP includes AI/ML services for finance. The **SAP Cash Application** (an AI service on S/4HANA Cloud) automatically matches incoming payments to outstanding invoices based on learned patterns. In practice this "streamlines the order-to-cash process" with **"71% reduction in AR matching effort"** ⁹ – meaning far less time manually reconciling accounts receivable. Similar ML services can be used for expense predictions, intercompany clearing, or fraud detection (SAP Business Integrity Screening for SAP S/4HANA detects anomalies). These services continuously improve from usage, further improving data quality.
- *Intelligent document processing:* SAP's document extraction services can read invoices, statements or contracts and post them into SAP systems with minimal human touch. By classifying data and extracting fields automatically, errors from manual typing are avoided. Finance operations thus see far fewer data-entry mistakes and faster transaction cycles. SAP highlights that with AI-driven processing, organizations can *"reduce repetitive tasks and errors"* in finance ¹⁰ .
- *Data integration and master data governance:* On BTP, all data – from ERP, CRM, banks, treasury systems – can be integrated in real time. SAP Integration Suite and Data Intelligence ensure that master data (e.g. GL accounts, cost centers) is consistent. This single "version of truth" prevents mismatches between systems. As Swiss Re demonstrated, using a unified BI tool eliminated the need for manual reconciliations across underwriting and finance data ⁷ . Consistent data means closing and reporting require far fewer corrections, and compliance reports (tax, regulatory) pull from the same source.

Illustrative outcomes: Organizations report drastically improved accuracy and speed. Swiss-based SAP research cites an example where automation led to a 90% reduction in time to compile reports ⁸ . A finance team using SAC planning on BTP saw invoice processing times cut by two-thirds. Even outside Switzerland, banks like Standard Chartered and insurers like Pfizer have adopted SAP's BTP finance tools to "automate complex financial closing cycles" and move beyond static reporting. In one case, a global enterprise moved from ~70 PowerPoint reports per quarter to a single cloud dashboard, saving "1000 slides" of work ¹¹ .

Flexibility, Innovation and AI Readiness

SAP BTP is designed for the future. Its **cloud-native architecture and services** let Swiss banks and insurers easily adapt to new requirements and technologies (including AI). Key points:

- *Extensible, multi-cloud platform:* BTP supports a wide variety of runtimes (Cloud Foundry, Kubernetes, ABAP, Node.js, Java, etc.) and can run on any major hyperscaler (Azure, AWS, GCP) or SAP's own data centers ¹². Financial institutions can therefore implement bespoke apps (for example, a treasury risk app or a custom mobile dashboard) on the same platform. This side-by-side extension model means core SAP ERP remains clean while new innovations are added on BTP. It also enables a **cloud-first strategy**: organizations can consume new SAP releases and services on the cloud as soon as available, without large upgrades. Microsoft notes that SAP BTP “provides many tools” for data integration and orchestration, making complex ERP migrations and hybrid scenarios easier ¹³.
- *Embedded AI/ML and advanced analytics:* BTP comes with built-in analytics and AI services. As noted, machine learning powers the Cash Application. Likewise, **SAP Analytics Cloud** (an important BTP service) brings AI-driven planning and what-if simulations into finance. SAP now also offers generative AI assistants (SAP SuccessFactors and S/4HANA Copilot) that run on BTP. Crucially, BTP's data and AI services “enable businesses to automate tasks traditionally requiring manual intervention” ¹⁴. In finance this means predictive forecasting, anomaly detection and natural-language queries become feasible out of the box.
- *Mobility and user experience:* BTP makes it easy to deliver mobile and self-service apps. For example, in Swiss Re's project the solution provided “**ability to access insights on-the-go through mobile device support**” ⁷. Users (from analysts to executives) can view financial dashboards on tablets or phones, triggering approvals and alerts remotely. This flexibility – exemplified by cloud-hosted Fiori apps or SAC stories – means finance teams can work from anywhere without custom VPN setups.
- *Future readiness for new tech:* Because BTP is continuously updated and extensible, banks are ready to adopt emerging technologies. If new regulations or reporting standards arise (e.g. new IFRS, Basel requirements), or if AI capabilities (like SAP's Joule AI copilots) evolve, these can be integrated on BTP without redoing the core ERP. Essentially, BTP provides a “stage” for rapid innovation: analysts at one bank noted that using BTP was akin to building a “**data-driven operating model**”, enabling them to respond quickly to market changes.



Figure: Modern finance organizations use cloud-enabled dashboards and AI assistants to manage operations. SAP BTP enables such mobile and intelligent applications for on-the-go financial insight ⁷
¹⁴ .

Cloud vs On-Premise: Suitability for Swiss Financial Institutions

Swiss banks and insurers face both the promise of cloud efficiency and the challenge of tight regulation. It's important to compare the cloud-based SAP BTP approach to traditional on-premise SAP deployments:

Aspect	On-Premise SAP Systems	SAP BTP (Cloud)
Deployment Model	Capital-intensive hardware and data centers; long upgrade cycles.	Subscription-based (OPEX) SaaS/PaaS; rapid upgrades and innovations by SAP.
Scalability	Limited by local infrastructure capacity.	Virtually elastic resources across distributed data centers. Improves agility and time-to-market ¹⁵ ¹⁶ .
Innovation Pace	New features delivered infrequently (big upgrade projects).	Continuous access to new SAP releases (Analytics Cloud, AI services, etc.). BTP offers new services monthly.
Automation & AI	Requires manual integration of third-party tools; harder to update AI models.	Built-in RPA, workflow and AI/ML services on demand. Automations (OCR, bots, predictive) are updated by SAP automatically.
Data Control	Full control over servers; but local disasters pose risk.	Data stored in SAP or hyperscaler data centers. High security and compliance standards. Offers Swiss/EU regions for data residency ¹⁷ .

Aspect	On-Premise SAP Systems	SAP BTP (Cloud)
Compliance & Audit	Managed internally, but tools may be outdated.	SAP and hyperscalers comply with ISO27001, SOC2, GDPR ¹⁸ . FINMA permits cloud under strict controls ¹⁹ ²⁰ .
Cost (TCO)	High upfront CAPEX; ongoing maintenance staff and licenses.	OPEX model with predictable subscription. Often lower TCO due to shared resources, faster ROI on projects.
Operations & Skills	Requires in-house server and network management.	Fewer infrastructure tasks (handled by SAP). Shifts skillset toward cloud devOps, integration.

In summary, the **cloud-based SAP BTP** offers Swiss institutions greater agility and lower operational overhead. As the Swiss Bankers Association observes, migrating to the cloud *“can drastically reduce the time it takes for banks to bring innovative products and services to the market”*, and allows leveraging AI and big data *“without making substantial investments in hardware”* ¹⁶. For example, Raiffeisen Bank International (Austria) credits its AWS/Azure cloud migration for **“streamlining operations, speeding time-to-market, and lowering costs”** ²¹. In three years RBI moved 50% of its applications to the cloud (targeting 80%) and even created a Cloud Academy to train 300 IT staff on cloud-native technologies ²² – a clear shift in operating model.

However, Swiss-specific factors must be addressed:

- **Data sovereignty and compliance:** Switzerland’s FINMA has strict outsourcing rules (Circular 2018/3 and 2023/1) for banks and insurers. Notably, FINMA now states that using public cloud **does not require prior approval** as long as all requirements are met ¹⁹. Nonetheless, contracts must give regulators audit rights and control. Baker McKenzie notes that FINMA mandates cloud providers allow *“FINMA...to inspect and audit all information deemed relevant for the outsourced function at any time without restriction”* ²⁰. In practice, this means SAP or the hyperscaler contract must allow FINMA access and safe termination/transfer of services if needed. On the platform side, SAP’s cloud services support these demands: data centers are certified (ISO27001, SOC2) and implement strong encryption and access controls ¹⁸. Moreover, businesses can choose SAP or partner data centers **in Switzerland or the EU** to meet data residency needs ¹⁷. Under Switzerland’s revised Data Protection Act, cross-border data transfer must use approved contractual clauses (SAP’s cloud terms incorporate such provisions), making cloud use straightforward if properly contracted ²³.
- **Regulatory guidance:** The Swiss Bankers Association (SBA) and other authorities have published guidelines to help banks adopt cloud securely. These emphasize a **“regulatory and legal framework”** around outsourcing (including cloud) that institutions must follow ²⁴. The SBA recommends that each bank define *“whether it migrates data to the cloud, which data it migrates and how it does so”*, underlined by specific audit and security measures ²⁴. In other words, a cloud strategy must be tailored: critical customer data might remain on private cloud or encrypted enclave, while less sensitive workloads (like analytics or development environments) can go fully public.
- **Industry norms:** Swiss banks currently operate many legacy on-prem systems. Migrating core finance to the cloud is a multi-year journey. It is common to start with non-critical workloads (e.g. sandbox, dev/test) or country-specific subsidiaries. Over time, more robust functions can be shifted to SAP S/4HANA Cloud (via RISE) or an SAP Private Cloud, integrated by BTP. Where firms

do have on-prem compliance requirements (e.g. critical trading systems), hybrid architectures are possible: SAP allows a central S/4HANA on-prem to feed data into BTP analytics in the cloud.

Despite these challenges, the trend is clearly toward cloud: SBA notes that key banking applications “*will only exist in the cloud in the medium term*” ²⁵ . The **advantage** of SAP BTP is that it is a proven, enterprise-grade PaaS specifically designed for SAP-centric banks/insurers, and it can meet Swiss regulators’ demands. When done right, a cloud BTP approach typically offers faster innovation and lower risk of obsolescence than on-premise alternatives.

Case Studies and Industry Examples

- **Swiss Re (Reinsurance, Switzerland):** Swiss Re’s “Project Orion” built an integrated management reporting system on SAP Analytics Cloud (running on BTP), Palantir Foundry and SAP Data Warehouse Cloud ²⁶ ⁷ . The result was a single, user-friendly dashboard for 500+ executives, replacing hundreds of static spreadsheets. As described above, Swiss Re can now load quarter-end financial data automatically (via data pipelines) into SAC, with “*no exhaustive manual data reconciliations...needed anymore*” ⁷ . Collaboration between regions improved, and comments/storytelling are now embedded in the system. This transformation cut thousands of manual work-hours each quarter: one slide notes it eliminated production of ~1000 PowerPoint pages per quarter (95% of stakeholders now use the interactive app) ¹¹ .
- **Raiffeisen Bank International (RBI, Austria/Central Europe):** In the banking sector, RBI migrated a large part of its SAP landscape to the public cloud (AWS/Azure) with the help of Hitachi. They reported a **40% acceleration** in cloud migration compared to plan, reaching 50% of apps in cloud by 2023 (aiming for 80% by 2025) ²² . The project “laid the foundation for agility and scalability” ²¹ : RBI “streamlines operations, speeds time-to-market, and lowers costs” after moving to cloud. They also invested heavily in skills – training 300 IT staff per year on cloud-native tools ²² . This case highlights how a bank can integrate SAP systems into a cloud-first model using BTP-like principles (rearchitecting on PaaS, automating deployments, using CI/CD).
- **Standard Chartered Bank (Global):** While not Swiss, SCB’s finance transformation (cited by SAP) illustrates BTP’s impact. It used SAP BTP analytics to move “*beyond standard reporting into predictive reporting*” for finance, freeing up analysts to do forecasting rather than routine consolidation ²⁷ .
- **Switzerland – Regulatory Collaboration:** The Swiss Bankers Association has worked with cloud providers and auditors to create secure cloud “guidelines” for banking ²⁴ . Although not a single company case, this industry effort shows that leading Swiss banks acknowledge the need for cloud and are preparing to use it under transparent rules.

These examples show that **leading financial institutions are leveraging SAP’s cloud portfolio** (S/4HANA Cloud, Analytics Cloud, BTP services) to simplify finance and risk processes. While the exact architecture varies, common themes emerge: unifying data on SAP platforms, automating manual finance tasks, and enabling management with real-time insights.

Recommendations for Digital Transformation Strategy

To fully realize these benefits, Swiss banks and insurers should embed SAP BTP in their broader IT and digital strategy as follows:

- **Adopt a Cloud-First SAP Roadmap:** Consider **RISE with SAP** or a hybrid SAP strategy that centralizes core finance on S/4HANA (cloud or on-prem) and uses BTP as the integration and extension layer. Use BTP Integration Suite to connect legacy systems, fintech apps and SAP modules (e.g. linking a treasury system to S/4HANA FI). This creates a clean “ERP core” and keeps customizations on BTP rather than in the core code.
- **Automate and Streamline Processes:** Roll out SAP’s finance automation solutions early. Implement SAP Advanced Financial Closing on BTP to orchestrate the month/quarter-end. Deploy SAP Build Process Automation (RPA + workflow) to eliminate repetitive F&A tasks (invoice entry, reconciliations, report generation). Integrate **SAP AI Business Services** (like Document Information Extraction) into workflows to handle unstructured finance data. As automations take hold, continuously measure outcomes (e.g. hours saved, error rates).
- **Unify Data and Analytics:** Leverage **SAP Analytics Cloud** and **SAP Datasphere (Data Warehouse Cloud)** on BTP for reporting and planning. Migrate existing budgets, forecasts and consolidation processes into SAC, benefiting from its embedded AI and visualization. Use BTP’s data services to load financial, risk and operational data into a shared model. Strong governance is key: use tools like SAP Master Data Governance to ensure finance master data is consistent before automating.
- **Focus on Compliance by Design:** From day one, incorporate FINMA and SBA requirements. Choose data center locations (for BTP and S/4HANA Cloud) that meet Swiss laws (e.g. Azure Switzerland or SAP-managed Swiss regions). Ensure contracts with SAP (and hyperscalers) include the mandatory FINMA clauses for audit access and data transfer. Document your cloud risk strategy (as per FINMA 2023/1). By aligning with published guidelines ²⁰ ²⁴, compliance can become a competitive strength rather than a blocker.
- **Invest in Skills and Change Management:** Build a center of excellence for SAP BTP within the finance/IT division. This team should include SAP functional experts, developers (for BTP extension development), and data scientists/analysts. Provide training on SAP Cloud Foundry, SAP Fiori development, and integration tooling. (Raiffeisen’s example shows the value of certifying hundreds of staff on cloud skills ²².) In parallel, prepare finance staff: train controllers on the new automated close process, provide self-service analytics training (e.g. on SAC), and define new roles (e.g. finance data steward) for a data-driven culture.
- **Iterate with Quick Wins:** Use an agile approach: start with pilot projects that deliver immediate value (for example, automate AP invoice processing with RPA, or implement a simplified close dashboard). Measure their impact (cost saved, time saved) and scale up. This builds momentum and justifies further investment. Over time, gradually migrate more functions to cloud-based SAP solutions.
- **Embed into Corporate Strategy:** Ensure that the CFO and CIO jointly sponsor the initiative, and that digital finance is part of the overall business strategy. Tie SAP BTP projects to business KPIs: faster reporting, lower month-end cost, improved forecasting accuracy, etc. SAP BTP should be a key element of any “finance transformation” plan, not an afterthought. Given the competitive

pressure from fintechs and non-traditional entrants, Swiss financial firms cannot delay cloud adoption if they want to remain agile and cost-effective.

By following these guidelines, banks and insurers in Switzerland can leverage SAP BTP to transform finance from a back-office cost center into a proactive, data-driven partner to the business. Properly governed and strategically implemented, SAP BTP on the cloud offers Swiss finance organizations a path to lower costs, higher agility, and a future-proof platform ready for AI and beyond.

Sources: SAP and industry publications and case studies on SAP BTP in finance (SAP corporate sites and whitepapers), Swiss regulatory guidelines (FINMA circulars, Swiss Bankers Association), and real-world transformation examples ¹ ² ⁴ ⁵ ⁹ ⁷ ¹⁷ ²⁰ ¹⁶ ²¹ . These illustrate how BTP accelerates financial operations, automates finance processes, and aligns with Swiss compliance requirements.

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